In the next listing, you see a web application that watches a local file for changes and displays the most recent value in a web page. When the file changes, the contents are read in and then assigned to a variable. The value of that variable is then used in the response to HTTP requests.

Listing 3.4. Serve the current contents of a file

```
fs = require 'fs'                          # Require the filesystem
http = require 'http'                      # and HTTP modules.

sourceFile = 'myfile'                      # Set some vars
fileContents = 'File not read yet.'        # for the app.

readSourceFile = ->                        # Function that
  fs.readFile sourceFile, 'utf-8', (error, data) ->   # asynchronously
    if error                               # reads the
      console.log error                    # source file.
    else
      fileContents = data

fs.watchFile sourceFile, readSourceFile    # Attach the file reader
                                           # to file change events.
server = http.createServer (request, response) ->   # Listen on HTTP
  response.end fileContents                # requests with
                                           # event handler.
server.listen 8080, '127.0.0.1'
```

This program uses events for reading a file, for watching a file for changes, and for responding to incoming HTTP request events. Every one of these events is handled by a callback function defined in the program.

Although the module system is covered in depth in chapter 12, you'll see two modules used in this chapter. They are the filesystem module (`fs`) and the HTTP module (`http`).

Filesystem module

The Node.js filesystem module `fs` provides reading from and writing to local files. In listing 3.4 the `fs.readFile` method, which you've already seen, is used in addition to the `fs.watchFile` method.

The `fs.watchFile` method takes a file and callback function. The file is polled for changes; when a change is detected, the callback is invoked. The